

Text: Ezra 4:2-3

Title: Build a true temple

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Introduction

If you have two roads, which one will you choose? One is easy and fast, and the other is difficult and slow. But there is one condition for easy road, you have to compromise with the enemy a little bit. For the hard road you need to fight against the enemy instead of compromising. If you have to make a choice one out of two, which one would you take?

One travel agent suggestion: About 13 years ago, my son was applying for Canadian visa for college, one travel agent suggested me like this. "It's hard to get a Canadian visa with your salary or property, so you need to make a paper company in order to show that you have enough money. The idea was to borrow money from someone and deposit it to the company account for a while and return back money. Many people use this way to get the visa", they said.

Of course, I said no. Because I didn't want to cheat someone to get a visa. I just applied visa with the money that I had. Do you know what the outcome was? My son got the visa and entered the university. In fact, he already graduated, got married and living there.

But not all results turn out as well as mine. When you make an honest decision, many times you either fail or have to make more sacrifices to achieve that result. So we often fall into the temptation to take the easy way out.

What does the Bible say about this? Did this situation exist in the Bible stories? Let's take a look.

Main Subject

1. Enemy's proposal

536 years before Jesus was born, there was a group of people in Jerusalem faced a similar situation. They are Jews who had been taken captive to Babylon and had return to Jerusalem to rebuild the Temple by the order of King Cyrus. They are about 42,000 Jewish people. They returned to Jerusalem, laid the foundation of the temple, and were about to begin the temple work earnestly. Then the Gentiles who had settled in the land long ago came to them, suggested like this. “Let us help you build because, like you, we seek your God and have been sacrificing to him since the time of Esarhaddon king of Assyria, who brought us here.” (Ezra 4:2) They were brought to Samaria by the Assyrian king (722 BC), and they lived there for about 180 years. They are the owners of the land now and had more power and authority than them. Some of them married with the Jews and some are even bring a sacrifice to the LORD on their altars.

Now! How should we discern their proposals in such cases?

First, we need to verify whether their suggestions are based on truth. They say that they offer sacrifices to Jehovah, but we must check whether their worship is true worship.

What can be quickly confirmed is that the worship they offer is not worship out of love for Jehovah, but rather an intention to receive additional blessings while already serving their own god. And the reason they proposed to build the temple together was to prevent the Jews from having great power of their own in Jerusalem after the temple was built. Zerubbabel and the elders(The leaders), understood their intention well. So they

chose the narrow way. They could have easily built the temple with their help if they had accepted their proposal, however, they decided to build the temple alone without their help.

Verse 3 “You have no part with us in building a temple to our God. We alone will build it for the LORD, the God of Israel, as King Cyrus, the king of Persia, commanded us.”

What was the result of this choice? They wrote letters to the Persian emperor and stopped the construction work for 16 years. (vv. 4, 24) This was the result of their righteous decision. Then, did they make wrong decision? Let us look more story.

2. If you worship me, I will give you everything.

Let us turn our eyes for a moment and go to the New Testament to look at the temptations the Lord faced and the choices the disciples made. The devil appeared to Jesus who was fasting for 40 days and tempted him three things. **If I interpret these three temptations in a comprehensive manner, it is as follows: “Choose easy way!”** Do not take a difficult way like the cross, but take the easy way. Become famous quickly by jump from the top of the temple! Get the world easily by bow down to me! However, the Lord rejected easy way. “Get behind me, Satan.” The Lord chose the Father’s way instead of easy way.

How would the history gone if Joseph had chosen the easy path? When Potiphar’s wife tempted him, if he compromised with her, he would have avoided prison. If Daniel had not opened his window and prayed after the king’s decreed was issued, he would have avoided the lion’s den. If John the Baptist had not told Herod that it was wrong to take another wife and marry her, he would not have been beheaded in

prison.

Jesus would not have been crucified if he had not healed the sick on the Sabbath and did not say that he was the Son of God. If we do not preach the gospel and keep our mouths shut, no one will persecute us. The way to avoid suffering is very simple. Just take the wide road like others. But when we choose to walk the narrow path and begin to speak the truth, suffering and persecution will come to us.

3. The Narrow Way is late but right Way

What was the ultimate outcome of the choices made by Zerubbabel and the Jewish leaders? For 16 years, construction had stopped and the people were waist time in confusion. Some people were busy in building their own houses. After that, when God's time came, God raised up two prophets. Haggai and Zechariah. Through Haggai, God spoke straightforwardly. Haggai 1:8, "Go up into the mountains and bring down timber and build the house, so that I may take pleasure in it and be honored." Even you eat but you are not full, even you put money into your purse, your purse is empty because you have a purse with a hole in it. This is because I have blown away your blessings. (v. 9)

After hearing God's demand through Haggai, Zerubbabel and the people of Jew resume the building work. By the help of God's hand, Persian Emperor gave permission and support the resources for the work. (Ezra 6:8-9) The work of the Jerusalem temple accelerates and is completed in the sixth year of King Darius (December 3). It was completed in 516 BC and dedicated the following year. And when the time was calculated, it was exactly 70 years after the desolation of Jerusalem, just in time for Jeremiah's prophecy to be fulfilled. God's perfect timing. I've

preached on this point before sermon.

But here's what I want to emphasize today.

Q1. Since the words of the prophet Haggai were enough to rebuild the temple, why did God call Zechariah as well? While Haggai focused on the “physical construction” of the temple, Zechariah emphasized ‘spiritual meaning of the temple and God’s promise for the future’.

First, spiritual restoration for Israel. “Return to me, and then I will return to you.” (Zechariah 1:3) God will remove the filthy garments of Joshua the high priest and put a crown on his head. (Zechariah 3:4-5)

And He will send the Messiah. Most important prophecy!

Zech 9:9, "Rejoice greatly, O Daughter of Zion! Shout, Daughter of Jerusalem! See, your king comes to you, righteous and having salvation, gentle and riding on a donkey."

What are the consequences of Christ's coming? 1) You will be blessed among the Gentiles. “As you have been an object of cursing among the nations, O Judah and Israel, so will I save you, and you will be a blessing.” (Zechariah 8:13) 2) You will shine like a jewel in a crown. (My favorite Bible verse) “The LORD their God will save them on that day as the flock of his people; they will sparkle in his land like jewels in a crown.” (Zechariah 9:16)

When that day comes, the Lord will reign completely, and the Gentiles will serve Him. Zechariah 14:9, “The LORD will be king over the whole earth. On that day there will be one LORD, and his name the only name.” Gentile worship. Verse 16, “Then the survivors from all the nations that have attacked Jerusalem will go up year after year to worship the King, the LORD Almighty, and to celebrate the Feast of Tabernacles.”

This is the message of hope that God gave through Zechariah:
1) He will restore Israel spiritually. 2) He will send Christ. 3) Ultimately, a world will come in which God will completely rule.

Conclusion

The narrow path that Zerubbabel and the leaders of Judah chose took time, but in the end, the temple was completed finally, and there spiritual blessings that is more important than the temple building, 'the coming of the Messiah'.

In this way, our right choices can bring blessings that exceed our expectations. That is why we must always do our best to make the right choices. The method of making those choices is the way that the Bible teaches. It is a slow but right way, a difficult but blessed path.

Jesus came to this earth (500 years) later and said, "Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it again." What does it mean? He will become a true temple. What is the main purpose of temple? 'Forgiving sins through sacrifice.' Jesus abolished animal sacrifice and provided a new way to forgive human's sin through the cross. He offered himself as atoning sacrifice to forgive all human's sin. His one sacrifice become valuable to forgive all human's past, present, and future sins. Even the next generations to come. In this way, Jesus Himself became the living temple of God. He also gave us the Holy Spirit, made us as temple where the Holy Spirit dwell. Isn't it amazing?

Therefore, there is no need of Jerusalem temple anymore. However, extreme Jews still desire to rebuild Jerusalem temple.

They already prepared everything (vessel, curtain, Ark of God etc) and waiting for the opportunity to start the building work. This information I heard from tour guider in Jerusalem during my visit of Jerusalem. However, they are making unnecessary efforts because they do not know the true temple of God, Jesus.

Therefore, God will not command us to bring wood from the mountain and build the temple in Jerusalem. **Instead, He will tell us to go to the world and preach the gospel.** Through that there will so many temple, where the Holy Spirit dwells will be built. **You may go to the world and build the temple of God!** This is the message God is giving us today. May God bless you!